

You keep comparing the same options, again and again

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 1 myth · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

For someone who has been circling the same two or three options for days, going over the details again hoping this pass finally makes the choice obvious, and starting to wonder if something is wrong with how they decide.

THE GOAL

You're trying to reach a decision you can commit to, not find objective proof that one option is better.

CHECKLIST

You've just sat back down to go through the same two or three options again.

- ☐ Go into this pass **ready to accept either option**, not hunting for a hidden reason it's better than the other.
- ☐ Check what's changed since you last looked: price, deadline, availability, a new fact. If nothing has, decide now; if something has, weigh it in first.
- ☐ Name, out loud or on paper, which option you leaned toward the last time you looked at this.
- ☐ If a new option occurs to you right now, set it aside instead of looking into it.
- ☐ If you end up with the worse pick, name the worst result and whether it fades quickly or lingers.
- ☐ Pick one concrete method you'll use if the options stay this close, and name it.
- ☐ Set a **specific day and time** you'll decide by, and write it somewhere you'll see it.
- ☐ If somebody else is waiting on this, tell them when you'll have an answer.
- ☐ Name your pick now if you can. If not, return on the day you set and use whatever tie-break method you chose.
- ☐ Say or write the decision as one plain sentence: "I'm going with this one."
- ☐ Do one small, concrete thing right now that **makes this choice harder to walk back**.
- ☐ Write down, in one line, whatever finally decided it, so you can reuse that next time.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Running the same comparison again just makes **whichever option you already favor** look better.
- 2 People who chase the **best** option instead of settling for good enough score lower on happiness and higher on regret.
- 3 When both options are good, leaving the decision unmade for a while is a common response, not proof that something is wrong with how you decide.

What running the comparison again actually does

KNOW

Running the same comparison again just makes **whichever option you already favor** look better.

As you lean toward an option, its downsides start looking smaller and its upsides bigger, purely from the leaning itself. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

People who chase the **best** option instead of settling for good enough score lower on happiness and higher on regret.

People who scored high on wanting the best showed this same pattern whether they were college students or working adults. [Source 2](#)

DON'T

Extra searching can land you an objectively better pick and still leave you feeling worse about it.

The harder you search, the more almost-picked options you have to regret, and that regret is what costs you the satisfaction. [Source 2](#)

Not choosing is a choice too

KNOW

When the choice includes what you already have, waiting isn't neutral. It already means keeping what you have.

In real choices, like which health plan to keep, people stick with the current pick far more often than a fresh comparison would justify. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

The urge to look for another option is a signal that the options in front of you are hard to separate, close enough that neither clearly wins.

People given closely matched options paid to see another far more often than people given a clearly better option. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

When both options are good, leaving the decision unmade for a while is a common response, not proof that something is wrong with how you decide.

You put off deciding because working out which good option truly wins feels hard, not because you lack information. [Source 4](#)

What happens once you actually commit

DON'T

Keeping the option to change your mind costs you: people who can still swap their pick end up liking it **less** than people whose choice is final.

Once a choice is final, your mind works to make you like it more, and staying reversible switches that process off. [Source 5](#)

KNOW

You're probably overestimating how long a wrong pick will sting. People underestimate this even after a breakup or missing a promotion, so a smaller letdown fades faster than it feels like it will.

You don't expect your own mind to make bad feelings fade, so you overestimate how long the sting will last. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Wait long enough without deciding and you'll eventually just know which one is right.

ACTUALLY

The feeling of finally knowing rarely arrives on its own. What usually happens instead is that people end up **sticking with whatever they already have**, because leaving a decision unmade favors it over anything else. [Source 3](#)

Sources

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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Decisions and judgment at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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